

CAMBRIDGE HARKENER

CELEBRATING THE HERITAGE OF CAMBRIDGE, VERMONT

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President's Review of 2024 CHS Activities

Joel Page, CHS President

It has been another busy year for the Cambridge Historical Society. We presented seven programs, published several issues of the Harkener, continued to organize our collection, and made more progress with technology upgrades. We did not suffer from flooding! Here are the details.

The seven programs covered a wide range of topics. Most were recorded and many can be viewed on Facebook though a link on the CHS Facebook page, or by links on our website (www.cambridgehistoricalsociety.org). The programs were:

April: The Far Traveler, by Nancy Brown

May: Smugglers' Notch - Trouble with Trucks, by Seth Jensen

June: History of Athletics at Cambridge High School, by Spencer Noble

July: Pirate History, and the Green Mountain Byway, by Ron Carter

August: The History of Alcohol, by Rebecca Rupp

September: The History of Maps, by Liam Kearney

October: A Conversation with Jane Shaw about the history of the Bryan Gallery

Several issues of our newsletter "The Harkener" were published and distributed to members. Production of The Harkener is mostly due to the talent and efforts of Geana Little. Thanks Geana! This year the Harkener features a serialized biography of Robert Murray Burns of Cady Hill, written by the Wilcox family. Check it out!

In February the CHS Board of Directors engaged Media Factory to assess our technology needs and to prepare a proposal for equipment purchases and installation. The assessment was completed and several proposals, of varying cost, were presented. Media Factory generously offered to donate two high quality cameras, two banks of lights, and a projector. The donated equipment, supplemented by a few items which CHS purchased, greatly improves our ability to record programs and interviews. With the help of the \$2,000 ARPA grant and a \$500 Eagles Club donation received last year, these tech upgrades have been accomplished with only a modest cash outlay by CHS. I want to say a special thanks to Board member Richard Gagne, who has guided our tech efforts, handled most of the Media Factory interactions, and is the man behind the cameras recording programs and interviews. Thanks Richard!

The Collections Committee continues to meet regularly and plug away at digitizing and cataloging those items that are appropriate for digitizing. Someday we hope you will be able to electronically access most of our collected items. Peter Opstrup, Jim Lonergan, and Hugh List

Early History of Cambridge

by Ida Morgan Anderson

Beginning in 1935, Ida Morgan Anderson began serializing a column on the History of Cambridge in the *Cambridge Town Crier*. Many of our readers may remember the series of 27 Installments. The Harkener continues publishing the installments for a new audience on the assumption that the copyright (if it ever existed) has long since expired. We hope you will enjoy these "blasts from the past."

Installment Twenty-three

As the first settlers in Cambridge located near the Boro it seems reasonable to infer that the first cemetery must have been the one known as Mountain View Cemetery where many of the pioneers are buried. A committee of five men and five women were appointed to select the location. The land must have been set aside for this purpose as there is no record of its having been brought by of anyone [sic]. More land has been added to it by purchase but lots in the original part are free and always have been.

At first the road from the harbor rode up the hill through the orchard on the Merritt Morgan farm and ran past it. Some man bought the land on three sides and in front of it. Later this farm was sold to W. D. Macoy. Years after, the road was changed and built around the foot of the hill, and the old road past the cemetery was given up.

This left it within the boundaries of the Macoy farm, and it was reached by a few rods of private road extending to the main road. Shaded by great elms and pines with beautiful view of mountains, hills, valley and river, it would be hard to find a more peaceful, restful spot than this serene hilltop. However far away sons and daughters of the old stock may wander in life they are brought back here for their last sleep among their kindred.

It had been a cherished ambition of Eben Mudgett and his sister, Mrs. Emily Mudgett Foster, descendants of one of the pioneers, to aid this cemetery with their property. Mr. Mudget died many years ago, and when Mrs. Foster died in 1905, it was found that she had willed \$5,475 to the cemetery. After bequests to her relatives the will states: "The balance or residue of my estate, both real and personal, I give for the benefit of the cemetery near the Boro wherein my family is buried. The interest only to be expended annually in the beautifying and keeping in proper order the stones, particularly those of my own family, but no part to be used on the fence. Said fund to be managed by a trustee or trustees elected at the annual Town Meeting."

She also expressed a wish that it might have a rose hedge and other shrubs like a cemetery in Bakersfield which was endowed by Peter Brent Brigham. To the library in North Cambridge she left the **American Cyclopedia** in twenty-three volumes and a sum of money.

The cemetery has had other bequests: in 1909 from Sheldon Stratton's estate \$3,120; in 1912 from Levi Wood's estate \$1,778; from Mrs. Asnath Cutting's estate \$500, the interest to be used in caring for her lot.

In 1913, \$2,500 from the Stratton bequest was used to buy the Macoy farm to provide a home for the sexton and caretaker.

The most thrilling experience the town has ever known was the flood of 1927 which devastated a part of the entire state. So great was the destruction that President Coolidge sent Herbert Hoover to investigate and help in the restoration. Offers of help came from various states by [sic] Governor John Weeks voiced the spirit of sturdy independence of the state in his reply that while deeply grateful for their offers, he thought that Vermont could repair damages without outside help. Mr. Hoover said "Vermonters are marvelous". and added that they were the only people he ever saw who were reluctant to accept help.

A reprint of an account of this disaster may be of some interest, and will form a fitting ending for this fragmentary history of our town among the hills.

The third of November, 1927, was a gray day without a ray of sunshine or a breath of wind. The gray sky seemed almost to touch the hills, and the warm, unnatural stillness held a hint of something ominous.

There was a feeling of hushed expectancy in the air as if danger was impending. We said "There's a hard storm brewing."

At dark the rain began. Gently at first, but increasing in violence till it poured down in sheets. All through Thursday and Thursday night it rained. Friday dawned cold and gray, still raining a little.

The brooks had grown to small rivers and water stood in puddles all over the ground. "The rivers must be pretty high and when the papers come we shall read of lots of damage," we said.

Before eleven, a passing neighbor shouted "Say! They are having an awful time at the village. The river is washing folks right out of their houses. They are taking them out of the chamber windows in boats. I've been over to Fletcher, around through North Cambridge, and bought all the bread and things they had in the store, to feed the folks with. Shepardson is going to send to St. Albans and get more, as quick as he can."

After a hurried dinner we started out. A cold gray flood covered the valley. It was half-way up to the windows of the two houses at the foot of the hill below the cemetery. It covered the eaves of the old steam mill. It nearly reached the eaves of the houses belonging to Mrs. Bernice Blaisdell and Merrill Clark on the other side of the river. On the high ground at the west end of the village cattle, hastily turned out of the barns to save their lives, were huddled together in shivering groups. In the road below Mountain View Cemetery a group of refugees stood looking down on their partly submerged homes and told us of their rescue.

are the brains behind this operation, thank you gents!

The Finance Committee and the Board regularly review our budget and our finances. We have an investment account that, depending on the market, provides a modest income stream. Presently, our income from membership dues, donations, and book sales does not cover expenses, so we are relying on some of the investment income to make up the difference.

Our membership numbers are fairly stable. We presently have over 90 members. We have not had much luck attracting younger members. This is a real concern for the Board of Directors, and we will continue to explore ways to connect with students, their parents, and “the younger generation”.

CHS continues to collaborate with other groups to enhance our community. This year we were involved in:

- A collaboration with the Bryan Gallery to present public conversations with Alden Bryan Jr., Jane Shaw, and Eric Tobin. The first two programs have been presented, and were very well attended. They were recorded by Richard Gagne using our equipment and will soon be available for viewing. The third program had to be rescheduled, but hopefully will occur soon.
- A collaboration with a Civil War group (Stannard Group of the Sons of Union Veterans of the Civil War) about the Grand Army of the Republic (GAR). Liam McKone gave a presentation that was recorded and should be available in the near future.
- Collaboration with Cambridge Elementary School to present a number of local history programs.
- Collaboration with the Vermont Historical Society and ABC 22/Fox 44. This led to production of four videos that highlighted the Wrong Way Bridge, the Civil War monument in Cambridge Village, the Warner Lodge, and the War Memorial in Jeffersonville. Links to these videos are now (or will soon be) available on the CHS Facebook page.
- Collaboration with producers of Vermont Public’s “Brave Little State” for an audio feature about Pumpkin Harbor, with most of the information provided by Jen Bartlau.

On the Fourth of July we held an Open House that was very well attended, probably in excess of 100 people. We even attracted a few new members! The historic Masonic Lodge on the second floor was open, and Peter Opstrup was kept busy giving tours and answering questions.

The 250th anniversary of the Revolutionary War is being celebrated around the State, and CHS (mostly through the efforts of Jen Bartlau) is assembling a big project. It will focus on the first settlers of Cambridge who had documented military service in the war. This project could expand, details are still being worked out. Thanks Jen for your amazing work on this original project!

We received a pleasant surprise at our Annual Meeting in November. Mary and Robert Coburn arranged and paid for the repair and rebinding of three volumes of old newspapers; two volumes of the Cambridge Transcript (1888-89, and 1900), and one volume of the Lamoille Valley Sentinel (1901-2). The donation was in memory of Mary’s father, Wendell T. Wells (Stub), 1912-2006. It is possible that more volumes will be repaired in the future. Thank you Mary and Robert!

I am very proud of what CHS has accomplished this year, and I continue to be very optimistic about our future. Our programs and projects make important contributions to our community. My thanks to the volunteers, Board, Officers, and members who have worked so hard to accomplish so much.

Robert Murray Burns

1895-1977

Reg Wilcox, Carol Wilcox Gray, Richard Wilcox

Installment IV

On May 31, 1960 Uncle Rob wrote in his diary, "went to creamery for the last time. Put cows and yearlings in barnyard and they all went at 2 this p.m. - 20 head in all". The next few years were busy ones on the farm - keeping up the farmland, liquidating farm tools, tapping a few trees in the spring, boiling down the sap and growing a large garden. In June of 1962 Uncle Rob and Aunt Gertie started the process of selling their beloved Tip Top Farm and moving to 134 N. Main St. in Cambridge Village next to the United Church. They started packing in September and began moving things to their village home. On October 31 Uncle Rob wrote in his diary "Jack and Henry moved the refrigerator and electric stove down, and we stayed down for the 1st time." On November 1 he wrote "Reg brought TV down this am." Uncle Rob liked to watch many sports on television. His diary from 1960 to 1964 lists the games and their scores. The sales agreement for the farm was signed on November 19. Rob and Gertie continued moving the last of their things through December. The farm was sold and deeded to Leonard and Donna Schneider on March 13, 1963.

Rob and Gertie continued to have a very active and busy life in Cambridge Village. Our typical family gatherings continued in their beautiful new Cambridge home. They maintained flower beds, a vegetable garden and Aunt Gertie continued to can produce. They shared Aunt Gertie's baking and the garden produce with friends and family. They had many friends in the village and beyond who they visited and who came to their home. Uncle Rob and Aunt Gertie continued to be very faithful in visiting his sister Carlie Burns Wilcox (our grandmother) at her home on Cady Hill, after they moved to the village.

Richard and his wife Theresa remember Uncle Rob and Aunt Gertie being just wonderful people always caring about others. Uncle Rob loved baseball and watched and recorded scores in his diary very often. Richard and Theresa remember visiting Uncle Rob in Cambridge during a baseball game. He just loved to visit with them, but only during commercials, he wanted to see every pitch and hear every word the commentators spoke!

Uncle Rob saw and lived the hell of war in Europe. This experience led him to value life and every relationship for the remainder of his life with us. Uncle Rob was a most Humble Man.

Jennie Chase Burns was a descendant of Thomas Rogers, a passenger on the Mayflower at the 1620 landing in Plymouth. Jennie, an eleventh generation descendant of Thomas Rogers, and all of her descendants are qualified to become members of the Mayflower Society. It seems somewhat ironic that the descendants of Mayflower passengers, who escaped from a hostile government in Europe, would themselves be called to Europe three centuries later to control another hostile government. We doubt that Uncle Rob or his siblings were aware of this during their lifetimes. We do not recall that the Mayflower landing was ever a topic of conversation within the Burns or Wilcox families.

We extend very sincere posthumous Thank You to our Uncle Rob for his service to the citizens of the United States and to the citizens of France during WW I.

We have tremendous admiration for Uncle Rob and Don Brown for their dedicated diary and letter writing from both the battlefields and hospitals of France. Perhaps this mental activity served to open a brief window from the evil of war into a more sane world for them.

We extend sincere posthumous Thank You to Uncle Rob's widow, Gertrude Burns, for

her preservation and good stewardship of Rob's and Don Brown's notes and letters before entrusting them to David Gates and entrusting Don's diaries to Richard and Theresa Wilcox.

Finally, we sincerely thank David Gates for his excellent stewardship of the documents and artifacts from Uncle Rob's and Don Brown's WW I service.

THE END



Membership Application/Renewal

Please complete this form and mail to: Cambridge Historical Society
PO Box 16
Jeffersonville, VT 05464-0016
or email to: rgtle@stoweaccess.com

☐ New

☐ Renewal

Name _____

Address _____
Number Street Town State Zip

Phone _____ E-Mail _____

Membership Category

☐ Individual \$20.00

☐ Family \$30.00

☐ Business \$30.00

Please consider becoming a:

☐ Patron \$500.00

☐ Benefactor \$1,000.00+

☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

If you have suggestions about program topics or have some great ideas for fundraisers,
please let us know by listing your ideas below.

Cambridge Historical Society
PO Box 16
Jeffersonville, VT 05464



Everyone should have received the notice of renewal for another year of membership in the Cambridge Historical Society. If you have not yet renewed please do so soon. This will be the last Harkener sent to members with a 2024 membership. To continue receiving this newsletter, however sporadically, renew now.

THANK YOU.